

OVOD EXPANDING its brand abroad

Sheikh Salim Taman Al Mashani, MD, Omani Vegetable Oils & Derivatives Company LLC (OVOD), and Sasi Kumar, CEO, OVOD, extend their warmest congratulations on Oman's 48th Glorious National Day and use this opportunity to extend heartfelt wishes for the continued good health and happiness of His Majesty Sultan Qaboos and the Omani people, as well as the lasting prosperity of the Sultanate of Oman

Sasi Kumar and Sheikh Salim Al Mashani have been driving the success of OVOD, thanks to the right economic infrastructure and business friendly environment put in place by the Government of His Majesty the Sultan. Sasi Kumar says success of any organisation depends on its employees and "we are proud to have high level of multi skilled employees whose thought processes are aligned to the strategic goals and vision set by our MD Sheikh Salim Al Mashani".

A dynamic young, farsighted executive, Kumar has been nurturing



Sasi Kumar, CEO, OVOD

OVOD's growth for last 11 years — first as its General Manager & Profit Centre Head (2007-Jun 2017) and since Jun 2017 as the CEO. Having a strong academic background with a Master's in Business Administration and a fellow of the prestigious Cranfield School of Management, Kumar is known for his dynamic and collaborative approach.

Sasi Kumar has almost 25 years of professional experience in the FMCG space, including over 11 years with Coca-Cola Company. An outstanding team collaborator, he always prefers to lead



from the front. Kumar is passionate in whatever he does, always tries to motivate people to believe in themselves. Mark Chapman of UK's Brand Active says "Kumar is professional, hardworking and a dedicated person, a joy to work with and a great problem solver. His knowledge of manufacturing and implementation is second to none and would be an asset to any company he works for". Sanjay Lamba, MD, Sainov Spirits Private Limited, says "Sasi Kumar is an excellent, intelligent, proactive and dedicated resource. He has worked under some of the most difficult situations and converted adversities into real business opportunities".

Kumar has a burning desire to succeed and strongly believes that there are solutions for every problems and problems are only temporary. He along with his

team has been contributing as much as he can for the growth and development of OVOD over last 11 years. This has been in the form of increase in OVOD's Top Line numbers, establishment of new branches, generation of additional employment opportunities and additional investment of around \$ 8 million in last five years. OVOD has always tried to increase the In-Country Value by supporting local manufacturers. Moreover, OVOD uses locally available materials so as to boost manufacturing industries in Oman.

OVOD has accorded utmost importance to Omanisation – and accordingly, training is regularly imparted to the employees. There are many Omanis working in the company and OVOD management is keen to empower them more and more because they have to take

the lead for the growth of this organisation in future. They should rise to various positions and understand the business dynamics and OVOD's human resource development (HRD) department is very clear on this aspect. The HRD wing has instituted certain programmes to hone the skills of the personnel and a number of staff members have been sent abroad to undergo training to update their technical knowledge and other specifics relating to the edible oil industry.

HISTORICAL OVERVIEW

OVOD is promoted by three prominent business enterprises in Oman – Dhofar Insurance Co SAOG, Dhofar Cattle Feed Co SAOG & Dhofar International Development & Investment Holding Co SAOG. The company is mainly into refining, manufacturing, distributing & selling of various consumer packs of edible vegetable oils ranging from 750ml to 20lt in HDPE, PET and Tins. OVOD also caters to institutional supplies by using the bulk transportation system.

OVOD uses multi-model distribution channels across the MENA region and continues to expand its business vertically to meet the emerging needs of customers by venturing into distribution of other FMCGs. Private labelling is one area upon which the company has laid more emphasis – and this activity constitutes around 45 per cent of the total volumes

at present. Today, OVOD is one of the largest suppliers of edible oil products in the GCC region with around 90 private labels. OVOD has grown to become one of the leading cooking oil suppliers not only in Oman but also in as many as 20 countries across the Middle East and Africa region.

Since OVOD is in the FMCG business, its strength is all about its distribution network – and that is the reason why “we started subsidiaries, opened warehousing facilities and also established distribution network across the GCC region” adds Sasi Kumar.

Growth in export market is also very much on the agenda for OVOD. After stabilising the business in Oman, the company started expanding its GCC footprint, initially by starting a 100 percent subsidiary in the UAE in 2012 with multiple warehouses in Dubai, Ajman & Abu Dhabi. As Saudi Arabia's population started growing, OVOD started another subsidiary in the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia in 2013. The company also opened two warehousing facilities – one in Riyadh, one in Jeddah – and efforts are being made to open a third such facility in the coming months in Dammam. Plans are also underway to open similar facilities in Kuwait, Qatar and Bahrain by 2019.

Exports contribute to 75% of OVOD volumes and this is showing an increasing

trend Year on Year. During 2017, OVOD was successful in registering a 29% growth in its Top line numbers which is well above the industry average of 5 to 7 per cent.

A young and energetic professional, Kumar provides strong encouragement and motivation to his team through his delegating style. As a visionary, technologically savvy and entrepreneurial executive, Kumar has been ably leading the company. Some of the OVOD milestones are: From a humble beginning in 2005, OVOD has now registered 10-fold increase in its turnover; OVOD products are now available in more than 20 countries; it has 8 branch offices across GCC; OVOD provides jobs to more than 250 permanent employees and around 70 casual workers; as part of its women empowerment drive, OVOD provides employment opportunities to Omani ladies across all its sections, which in turn helps them to make career progression; OVOD actively promotes “Origin Oman” campaign by buying Omani products and services; OVOD always uses 100% virgin material in all its packaging materials so as to comply with Environmental and Food Safety measures; OVOD has been continuously investing a good amount in adopting latest technology so as to reduce the cost of production; and cost saving is passed on to the final consumers by reduction in selling price. OVOD is expecting organic growth in the coming years and has drawn up short-term and



long-term strategic framework as part of developing the business. OVOD plans to expand its product line by adding both a premium and a budget brand of oil to meet different consumer segments.

AWARDS: OVOD has achieved Comprehensive Food Safety Management Systems (FSMS) by SGS Europe. The company has an integrated quality management system which consists of ISO 9001, 14001 and 22001. OVOD has also received HACCP and GMP certifications for implementing good manufacturing and distribution practices. OVOD was chosen as a nominee for the Best Regional Enterprise of the Year 2016 award by Europe Business Assembly. Further OVOD was nominated for the Sultan Qaboos Award for Industrial Excellence in 2017. The company has been associated with Charity programmes since its inception and is a preferred supplier for International organizations like Red Cross, World Food Programme, Red Crescent etc. OVOD received the Best Supplier Award in 2015 from Aswaaq LLC - UAE.